

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 7: Unit VI, Doing Theology Today (Lectures 30 to 35)

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These are your notes. Each lecture gives the opening problem, the teaching content, the references, the cross-references to the rest of the course, the illustrations for the board, and a teaching tip with the reading and the reflection prompt. The last lecture is the capstone of the whole course, and its notes are shaped to that end.

THE ARC OF UNIT VI

Unit VI is the destination of the whole course. It answers the sixth and last goal, how the student is to become a responsible theologian today, and it carries the fourth and final precept of Bernard Lonergan, be responsible. Everything has been moving toward this. The student learned what theology is and why it is done in Unit I, what its nature is in Unit II, where it draws its content in Unit III, how it grew through history in Unit IV, and how it is actually done, by what methods, in Unit V. Now he must take all of that into his own hands and ask the question on which his whole life as a thinking believer will turn: how shall I, here, in the real India of this hour, do theology faithfully and well? The four precepts now stand complete: the responsible theologian is attentive to the data, intelligent in seeking the meaning, reasonable in weighing and judging, and, at the last, responsible in deciding, acting, and answering for what he does. To be responsible, in the sense of Lonergan, is to move past merely knowing to deciding and doing, to ask not only what is true but what I ought to do about it, and to stand accountable for the answer before God, the Church, the truth, and the people one serves.

The unit moves in six steps, and the first four take up the great questions of the present age, the signs of these times that the Council taught the Church to read. Lecture 30 asks whether a machine can do theology, and faces the new world of artificial intelligence. Lecture 31 asks what a listening Church looks like, and takes up synodality. Lecture 32 asks whether the earth has a voice in theology, and takes up the care of our common home. Lecture 33 asks how we are to speak of Christ among the many faiths of India. Then the last two steps turn the question on the student himself. Lecture 34 asks directly what makes a theologian responsible, and holds the hard tension between obedience and prophecy. And Lecture 35, the capstone of the course, asks each student to answer, in his own voice and on his own responsibility, the question that has waited at the end of the road since the first day: how do I become a responsible theologian today? There he writes and speaks his own Theology Manifesto, and is sent out with a blessing.

The thread through all six is responsibility, which gathers up the other three precepts and adds decision to them. The sin against this unit is the theologian who knows much and

risks nothing, who can describe every method and answer every question of an examination, and who never decides, never acts, never stands accountable, never lets the truth he has studied change a single thing in the world or in himself. Keep the precept be responsible on the board for these six days, beside the questions of the age, and at the close of each class ask the students not only what they have understood but what, in the light of it, they now intend to do.

LECTURE 30: Can a machine do theology?

The opening problem. Bring the newest question of all into the room, for it is no longer science fiction but sits in the pocket of every student. There are now machines that can write a homily in thirty seconds, answer a question about the Trinity in fluent and confident prose, draft a retreat, summarise an encyclical, and produce, on demand, page after page of words about God that read as though a theologian had written them. So the question presses, and it presses on these very seminarians who are tempted to use such tools for their assignments: can a machine do theology? If a machine can produce the words of theology, is the theologian still needed, and what, if anything, can the praying believer do that the machine cannot? Pose it honestly, without panic and without scorn. The answer, which the Church has begun to give in the document *Antiqua et Nova*, is that a machine can arrange the words of theology with great skill, and can be a useful servant, but it cannot do theology, because theology is the act of a believing, praying, responsible person, and a machine is none of these.

The teaching content. What the machine can do, and what theology is. Be fair to the machine first, for the students must not despise a real and useful tool. Artificial intelligence can gather information, find references, draft and summarise, translate, and arrange language about God in ways that are often correct and sometimes beautiful, and used wisely it can serve the theologian as a swift and tireless assistant. But recall what theology actually is, from the very first lectures of this course. Theology is faith seeking understanding, from Lecture 2; it is the act of a believer who prays, from Lecture 29; it rises from the faith experience of a person and a community, the pillar of Lecture 23; it is done by a converted and authentic subject, the transcendental insight of Lecture 25; and it ends, at its height, in adoration. A machine has no faith. It does not pray. It has no experience of God, no conversion, no love, and it cannot adore. It can produce the sound of theology, every word in its place, while the one thing that makes theology theology, faith seeking the face of the living God, is simply absent. The machine handles the words about God the way a clever stranger might recite a love letter in a language he does not understand: the syllables are perfect, and there is no love in them.

Antiqua et Nova and the dignity of the human person. Give the students the heart of what the Church has said. The document *Antiqua et Nova*, whose very name means the ancient and the new, was given by the Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith together with the Dicastery for Culture and Education, and it sets out the difference between human intelligence and artificial intelligence. Human intelligence is the gift of a person made in

the image of God, embodied, relational, open to truth, to goodness, and to God himself, and it is bound up with a free will, a conscience, and a spiritual soul. What is called artificial intelligence is a powerful computation, narrow and astonishing at once, but it is not a person, it does not understand in the human sense, it does not will, and it must never be treated as though it were a subject, a conscience, or an oracle. The document warns against the real dangers: the deception of taking the machine for a person, the temptation to make of it a kind of idol or a substitute for God, the concentration of power it can bring, its use in war and surveillance, and its capacity to harm the poor and the worker. Through it all runs one steady line: the machine is a tool made by human beings, and human beings remain responsible for it, before God and before one another, which is the precept of this whole unit.

The responsible use, for a seminarian. Make it practical, because the students will use these tools whether you discuss them or not, and the responsible course must be taught. Used as a servant, artificial intelligence can help a busy priest find a reference, check a date, draft an outline, or arrange his notes, much as philosophy has always served as the handmaid of theology, from Lecture 11. But three things the responsible student must hold firm. He must never let the machine replace his own prayer, his own study, and his own thinking, for the day he hands those over, his theology begins to die, as Lecture 29 warned. He must never pass off the words of the machine as the fruit of his own faith, for that is a lie, and a theology degree, or a homily, built on such lies forms a hollow priest. And he must always test what the machine produces against the sources and the marks of Lecture 10, for these tools err confidently, inventing references and mixing truth with falsehood, and the believer, not the machine, is responsible for what is preached in the name of God. The machine can be the assistant; it can never be the theologian, because only a person can believe, pray, decide, and answer for what is said.

Illustration. The first image is the mynah bird that recites the prayer. A mynah can be taught to say the holy name perfectly, every syllable clear and in order, morning after morning, and yet the bird does not pray, for it has no faith and no love and does not know what it is saying; it makes the sound of prayer with no prayer inside it. A machine that produces theology is the mynah of the holy words: the sentences about God are flawless, and there is no faith behind them, no soul lifted toward God, nothing of what makes the words a prayer rather than a noise. To mistake the recitation of the bird for the prayer of a believer is the very confusion the students must learn to see through.

The second image is the calculator and the mathematician. A small calculator will work a long sum faster and more surely than any human mind, and a wise student is glad to use it; but the calculator does not know what mathematics is for, cannot tell which sum is worth doing, does not love the truth it spits out, and would not care if the answer were used to build a hospital or a bomb. The mathematician is the one who knows what it all means and what it is for, and who answers for the use of it. The machine is the calculator of words about God; the theologian is the believing person who knows what the words are for, who loves the One they point to, and who must answer, before God, for what he does with them. A calculator can hold the figures; it cannot hold the responsibility, and responsibility is the heart of this unit.

References. Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith and Dicastery for Culture and Education, *Antiqua et Nova: Note on the Relationship Between Artificial Intelligence and Human Intelligence* (2025), for the difference between human and artificial intelligence and the dignity and responsibility of the human person. For theology as faith seeking understanding and the act of a praying believer, Lecture 2 and Lecture 29. For philosophy, and now the new tools, as the handmaid of theology, Lecture 11. For the marks of authentic theology and the test of fidelity, Lecture 10.

Cross-references. The nature of theology as faith seeking understanding comes from Lecture 2, as the act of a praying believer from Lecture 29, as rising from faith experience from Lecture 23, and as the work of a converted subject from the transcendental model of Lecture 25. The handmaid that serves but does not rule comes from Lecture 11. The question whether God is real or only a human projection, raised by the masters of suspicion in Lecture 21, returns here in a new form, for a machine that arranges words about God with no God in view is the projection made mechanical. The precept be responsible governs the whole, for only a person can be responsible, and that is exactly what the machine can never be.

For the professor. Resist both the panic that would forbid these tools outright and the laziness that would let the students lean on them in place of prayer and study; teach instead the responsible middle, the machine as servant and never as master or as theologian. Be candid that they are tempted to use these tools for their very assignments, and set before them plainly the three firm lines: never replace your own prayer and thought, never pass off machine words as your own faith, and always test the output against the sources, for it errs with great confidence. Tie it to the whole course: the one thing the machine lacks is the one thing this course has been forming in them, a praying, converted, responsible person. Reading: *Antiqua et Nova*. Reflection prompt: "One way I could use these new tools as a servant in my ministry, and one line I will never let them cross, are..."

LECTURE 31: What does a listening Church look like?

The opening problem. Ask the students to picture two very different ways of being the Church. In the first, a few men at the top decide everything, and the rest of the People of God receive and obey, and are seldom asked anything at all. In the second, the whole People of God walk the road together, the bishops and the priests and the religious and the laity, the women and the young and the poor, all listening to one another and to the Holy Spirit before the Church decides and acts. Which of these is the Church of Jesus Christ? Pose the question, because the Church in our own day, through the Synod on synodality, has answered it with a clear stress on the second, and the students are being ordained into a Church that is learning, painfully and joyfully, to listen. The word synod itself says it: *syn* and *hodos*, together on the road, the whole Church walking as one. A listening Church is not a Church that has lost its nerve or its teaching; it is a Church that remembers that the Spirit speaks through the whole body, and that the faith of the least of the faithful is a true voice to be heard.

The teaching content. Synodality, and the faith of the whole people. Root synodality in something the students already hold firmly, the *sensus fidelium* of Lecture 14, the teaching of *Lumen Gentium* that the whole body of the faithful, anointed by the Holy One, cannot err in believing. If that is true, and it is the doctrine of the Church, then the faith of the whole People of God is a real source that the Church must listen to, and synodality is simply the Church taking her own doctrine seriously and building ways to listen. The Synod of 2024 and its Final Document, which Pope Francis chose to make part of the ordinary teaching of the Church, set out synodality as a constitutive dimension of the Church, not an optional style for one papacy but part of what the Church is: a communion of all the baptised, called to participation and to mission, walking together. This is the People of God of *Lumen Gentium*, from Lecture 22, becoming a way of living and deciding, and not only a phrase.

Communion, participation, mission, and conversation in the Spirit. Give the students the three words that carry the synodal vision, communion, participation, and mission.

Communion names what the Church is, the many made one in Christ. Participation names the call of every member, and not only the clergy, to take an active part in the life and the decisions of the Church, each according to his gift, so that the laity, the women, the young, and the poor are not a passive audience but sharers in the mission. Mission names what it is all for, for the Church listens and walks together not to please herself but to carry the Gospel more faithfully to the world. And give them the method the Synod has taught, conversation in the Spirit, in which people speak honestly and then, before answering, listen in silence to what God may be saying through the other, so that the meeting becomes a shared discernment and not a contest of opinions. This is the pastoral cycle of Lecture 23 and the listening that begins all good method, now made the ordinary way the Church takes counsel.

What it is, and what it is not. Guard the students against the two misunderstandings they will meet. Synodality is not the Church becoming a parliament, where truth is settled by counting votes and the majority overrules the Gospel; the listening is a listening for the Spirit, under the Word and within the apostolic order, and the teaching office remains the servant and guardian of the Word, from Lecture 14. Nor, on the other side, is synodality a soft word for doing nothing, an endless talking that never decides; true synodal listening is ordered to discernment, decision, and mission, which is the responsibility of this unit. Held rightly, it is neither a democracy that silences the Gospel nor a bureaucracy that silences the people; it is the whole body of Christ, each part with its own gift, listening together for the voice of its one Head. For a priest in Bengal this is daily and practical: it means the parish council that truly consults, the catechists and the women and the young actually heard, the Basic Christian Communities taken seriously, and the poor given a real voice and not only a seat at the back.

Illustration. The first image is the family that walks at the pace of the slowest. When a large family sets out together on a long road, to a wedding in a far village, the wise among them set the pace not by the strongest young man but by the oldest grandmother and the smallest child, so that the family arrives together, as a family. If the strong race ahead and leave the weak behind, they may reach the village sooner, but they arrive as a scattered handful and not as a family, and the ones left on the road are the ones who most needed to

be carried. The synodal Church is the family that walks at the pace that keeps everyone, and the test of its walking is whether the least, the poor, the wounded, the small, are still with it when it arrives. A Church that races ahead and leaves its weakest on the road has forgotten what kind of body it is.

The second image is the elder who lets everyone speak before he speaks. In many a village there is an elder known for one thing above all: when a hard matter comes to him, he sits long in silence and lets every person speak, the women, the young, the poor, the ones nobody usually asks, before he himself says a word, because long life has taught him that the truth of a matter is usually scattered in many mouths and must be gathered patiently by listening. We are given two ears and one mouth, the old saying runs, that we may listen twice as much as we speak. The listening Church is the Church that has learned the patience of that elder, gathering the scattered truth that the Spirit has placed in the whole People of God before she speaks and decides. The Church that speaks first and listens last has the order exactly backward.

References. The Synod of Bishops, *Final Document of the Second Session of the XVI Ordinary General Assembly* (2024), which Pope Francis approved as part of the ordinary teaching of the Church, for synodality as a constitutive dimension of the Church and for communion, participation, and mission. Lumen Gentium 12, for the *sensus fidei* of the whole People of God (cross-reference Lecture 14), and Lumen Gentium, Chapter 2, for the Church as the People of God (cross-reference Lecture 22). For conversation in the Spirit as the method of synodal discernment, the working documents of the Synod. For the pastoral cycle of listening, Lecture 23.

Cross-references. Synodality rests on the *sensus fidelium* of Lecture 14 and on the People of God of Lecture 22, and it puts into practice the listening that begins all good method in Lecture 23. It keeps the teaching office as servant and guardian, from Lecture 14, so that it is neither parliament nor bureaucracy. The real voice it gives the poor reaches back to Lecture 15 and Lecture 26, and the voice it gives women reaches back to Lecture 28. The discernment, decision, and mission to which it is ordered are the responsibility of this whole unit, and they prepare the responsible theologian of Lecture 34.

For the professor. Make this concrete, for synodality can float into abstraction. Ask the students how a parish council, a catechists meeting, or a Basic Christian Community in their own future parish could actually practise conversation in the Spirit, and let them see that synodality is a way of running a meeting and not only a theme for a lecture. Steer them firmly between the two errors, the Church as a vote-counting parliament and the Church as endless talk that never decides, and show that true listening is ordered to mission. Tie it to the doctrine they already hold, the faith-sense of the whole People of God, so that they see synodality as old truth in fresh practice and not a novelty. Reading: the Final Document of the 2024 Synod. Reflection prompt: "One group in my future parish whose voice is usually unheard, and one concrete way I could listen to them, are..."

The opening problem. For most of its history, theology spoke of God and the human person and said rather little about the soil, the river, the forest, and the air, as though creation were only the stage on which the drama of salvation was played and not part of the drama itself. Then the wounds of the earth grew too loud to ignore, and in Bengal they are very loud: the rising sea creeping into the Sundarbans, the cyclones that come harder and more often, the rivers that erode whole villages, the arsenic in the groundwater, the smoke of the kilns. So pose the question that *Laudato Si'* puts to the Church: does the earth have a voice in theology, and is the care of creation part of the Gospel or only a fashion of the times? The answer of Pope Francis, and of the Church, is that the care of our common home belongs to the heart of the faith, that the earth is not a warehouse to be emptied but a gift to be tended and even a sister to be loved, and that, decisively for everything this course has taught, the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor are one cry.

The teaching content. Integral ecology, and the one cry. Take the central insight of *Laudato Si'*, which the document calls integral ecology: everything is connected. We cannot harm the earth without harming the human beings, and above all the poor, who depend on it, and we cannot truly care for the poor while we ruin the world they live in. Pope Francis joins, in one phrase the students should carry, the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor, and shows that they are not two separate causes but one. This binds the new question of ecology straight into the heart of this course, for the cry of the poor was named a true source of theology in Lecture 15, was heard from below in liberation and Dalit theology in Lecture 26, and was made one strand of the rope of Indian theology in Lecture 27. The wound to the earth is felt first and worst by the poor, who cannot move away from the flood, the drought, and the poison, and so to care for creation is not a distraction from the option for the poor but a part of it.

Creation as gift, and the mind that forgets it. Give the students the deeper vision under the practical concern. The encyclical takes its very name from the Canticle of Saint Francis, *Laudato si', mi' Signore*, Praise be to you, my Lord, in which Francis called the sun his brother and the earth his sister and mother. Creation, in this vision, is a gift of the Creator, charged with his glory, given to the human family to tend and to keep and not to plunder, and the goods of the earth are meant for all, and not for the few who can seize them. Against this, Pope Francis sets the mind of the age, which he calls the technocratic mentality and the throwaway culture, the habit of treating everything, the earth and the poor alike, as raw material to be used and discarded for profit and convenience. The root of the wound is spiritual: a forgetting that the world is a gift and that we are its stewards and not its owners. The remedy is therefore also spiritual, a conversion, an ecological conversion, that learns again to receive the world with gratitude and to use it with restraint, justice, and love.

The payoff, for Bengal. Make it land where the students will serve. The Church of Bengal lives on the front line of this wound, among the rising waters of the delta, the eroding rivers, the displaced and the climate migrants who are almost always the poor. A theology and a pastoral practice that has nothing to say to a family whose land the river has eaten, or whose well has turned to poison, has failed the people. The responsible theologian of this

land must be able to read the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor as the one cry it is, to preach the care of creation as part of the Gospel, and to lead his people in small and real acts of stewardship, the planting of trees, the care of water, the refusal of the throwaway habit, as a part of their discipleship and not as something added on. To care for the common home is to love both the Creator and the neighbour, and above all the poor neighbour who suffers first when the home is wrecked.

Illustration. The first image is the kiln smoke and the poor child. When the brick kilns and the factories pour their smoke into the air over the basti, the rich man shuts his windows, runs his machine to clean the air of his own room, or leaves for the cool of the hills; but the poor child, in the shack beside the kiln, breathes that smoke night and day, and it is her small chest that fills first, her cough that comes first, her growth that is stunted first. The harm done to the air and the harm done to the poor are not two harms but one harm, falling first on the one least able to escape it. This is what it means to say that the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor are a single cry, and the one who would silence either must answer for both.

The second image is the earth as a sister, not a warehouse. There is all the difference in the world between how a man treats his sister and how he treats a warehouse of grain. His sister he honours, protects, and would never sell or strip bare; the warehouse he empties as fast as he can for the best price, and feels no loss when its shelves stand bare. The modern mind, Pope Francis says, has stopped seeing the earth as Sister and Mother, as Saint Francis saw her, and has started seeing her as a warehouse to be emptied, and from that one change of sight flows the whole plunder. To recover the care of creation is, first of all, to recover the sight that the earth is kin, a gift entrusted to a family of stewards, and not a heap of stuff belonging to whoever can grab it fastest. A man who remembered that the river is his sister would not poison her.

References. Pope Francis, *Laudato Si'* (2015), sections 1 to 16, for the praise of the Creator, the example of Saint Francis, integral ecology, and the call to care for our common home; and *Laudato Si'* 49, for the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor as one cry. The Canticle of the Creatures of Saint Francis of Assisi, for the sun as brother and the earth as sister and mother. For the cry of the poor as a true source of theology, Lecture 15; for theology from below, Lecture 26; for the strand of the poor in Indian theology, Lecture 27.

Cross-references. The care of creation binds straight into the cry of the poor of Lecture 15, the view from below of Lecture 26, and the threefold cord of Indian theology in Lecture 27, for the wound to the earth falls first on the poor. Creation as the gift of the Creator reaches back to revelation in deeds and the goodness of what God has made, from Lecture 3. The ecological conversion it asks for is an instance of the responsibility that governs this unit, and it prepares the responsible theologian of Lecture 34, who must answer for the world he leaves to the children of his people. The reading of the signs of the times, from Lecture 22, here reads the gravest sign of all.

For the professor. Ground this lecture in the soil and water of Bengal, for nowhere is the lesson nearer than in the delta, and let the students name the wounds they have seen with their own eyes, the eroding river, the rising sea, the poisoned well, the displaced family.

Hold the central insight at the centre: the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor are one cry, so that ecology is not a fashion borrowed from the West but a part of the option for the poor this course has taught from Lecture 15. End on the change of sight, from warehouse to sister, and on small and real acts of stewardship the students can lead their people in, so that the lecture issues in action, as this whole unit must. Reading: *Laudato Si'*, sections 1 to 16. Reflection prompt: "One wound to the earth that I have seen fall hardest on the poor, and one small act of care I could lead my people in, are..."

LECTURE 33: How do we speak of Christ among many faiths?

The opening problem. Set the students in the real India they will serve, where the Christian is a small minority among a great sea of faiths, the Hindu, the Muslim, the Buddhist, the Sikh, the Jain, and the many tribal traditions, and where their nearest neighbours, their friends, and often their own kin belong to other religions. Pose the question this raises, which is among the most delicate a priest in this land must answer: how do we speak of Christ among many faiths? How do we hold together, in one heart, two things that seem to pull apart, the conviction that Jesus Christ is the one Saviour of all, confessed at Nicaea and Chalcedon in Lecture 18, and a genuine respect for our neighbours of other faiths, a real readiness to learn from them and to live with them in peace? Pose it without softening either side, for the students will meet two easy and wrong answers, and must learn the harder, truer middle that the Church has taught.

The teaching content. The two errors to avoid. Name the two wrong answers plainly, for they are the ditches on either side of the road. The first is a narrow contempt that denies any truth, any goodness, any grace to the other faiths, treats the neighbour as a mere target for conversion, and lives among other believers as among enemies. The Church rejects this, for the Second Vatican Council taught in *Nostra Aetate*, from Lecture 22, that the Church rejects nothing of what is true and holy in the other religions, and that the Spirit of God is at work in ways past our seeing. The second error is the opposite, a relativism that says all religions are simply equal paths, that it does not finally matter which one you follow, and that Christ is only one teacher among many. The Church rejects this too, for it empties the Gospel and denies what the faith confesses, that in Christ alone God has given himself fully for the salvation of all. The reasonable and responsible course, from Lecture 24, is to refuse both ditches and walk the road between: to hold the uniqueness of Christ with full conviction, and to honour the work of God in the neighbour with full respect.

The Catholic middle: proclamation and dialogue. Give the students the shape of the Catholic answer, which holds three things together. First, Christ is the one Saviour of all, and the Church is sent to proclaim him to every people; this conviction the students must never surrender, for it is the heart of the faith. Second, the grace of God is genuinely at work beyond the visible borders of the Church, in the goodness, the prayer, the longing, and the truth found in other religions, so that the neighbour is not a godless void but a person in whom God may already be working. Third, dialogue, the patient, respectful, friendly meeting of believers of different faiths, in which each speaks honestly and each listens and

learns, is a true part of the mission of the Church, and not a betrayal of it, standing alongside proclamation and not against it. This is the strand of dialogue with the religions in the threefold cord of Indian theology from Lecture 27, and Michael Amaladoss and the Asian bishops have shown that the Church in Asia must be a Church of dialogue, witnessing to Christ above all by the quality of her love. The responsible theologian holds all three: he proclaims Christ with conviction, he respects and learns from his neighbour, and he gives a reason for the hope that is in him with gentleness and reverence (cf. 1 Peter 3:15).

The payoff, for Bengal. Make it concrete and daily. The students will live among Hindu and Muslim neighbours, will share the festivals and the sorrows of the locality, and will sometimes feel the heat of communal suspicion and the controversy over conversion. The lecture forms them to be, in that setting, neither the fearful Christian who locks his door against every neighbour nor the spineless one who pretends his faith is no different from any other, but the rooted and open believer who knows and loves Christ deeply, and precisely because of that secure rooting can be a friend to all, a man of peace, a builder of harmony, who witnesses to the Gospel chiefly by his love and his service to people of every faith, and who is ready, when asked, to speak of his hope with conviction and with gentleness.

Illustration. The first image is loving your own mother without insulting another. A man loves his own mother with his whole heart and would say, without hesitation, that she is the best of mothers; and yet this love does not drive him to go about insulting the mothers of other men. He can sit at his neighbour table, honour his neighbour mother, speak warmly of her goodness, and lose nothing of his own devotion, for love of his own does not require contempt for another. So the Christian holds Christ as the one Saviour with his whole heart, and is not thereby driven to insult or despise the faith of his neighbour, but can honour what is true and good in it, and remain entirely faithful to his own Lord. The one who thinks he must insult your mother to prove he loves his own has understood neither love.

The second image is the deep-rooted tree that gives shade to all. A tree whose roots go deep into its own soil is not anxious and not easily shaken, and precisely because it is so firmly rooted it can spread its branches wide and give shade and fruit to every passer-by, of any village and any faith, who rests beneath it. The shallow-rooted tree, by contrast, either clings to itself in fear and shades no one, or topples in the first strong wind that blows. The Christian rooted deeply in Christ is the deep-rooted tree: secure in his own faith, he is not threatened by the neighbour of another religion but can offer friendship, shade, and service freely, with nothing to fear. It is the half-rooted Christian, unsure of his own faith, who either grows fearful and closed or is blown away into thinking all faiths the same. Deep roots make wide branches.

References. The Second Vatican Council, *Nostra Aetate*, for what is true and holy in the other religions (cross-reference Lecture 22). The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Dominus Iesus* (2000), for the uniqueness of Christ and the Church against relativism. The Pontifical Council for Interreligious Dialogue and the Congregation for the Evangelisation of Peoples, *Dialogue and Proclamation* (1991), for dialogue and proclamation as both

belonging to the one mission. John Paul II, *Redemptoris Missio*, for Christ the one mediator and the Spirit at work beyond the visible Church. Michael Amaladoss, on dialogue and pluralism and the Asian face of Christ (cross-reference Lecture 27). 1 Peter 3:15, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition, for giving a reason for our hope with gentleness and reverence.

Cross-references. This lecture is the strand of dialogue with the religions in the threefold cord of Indian theology from Lecture 27, held together with the uniqueness of Christ confessed in Lecture 18. The respect for what is true and holy in other faiths comes from *Nostra Aetate* in Lecture 22, and the refusal of both ditches, contempt and relativism, rests on the reasonable weighing of Lecture 24 and the marks of Lecture 10. The witness by love and service reaches back to the cry of the poor of Lecture 15 and Lecture 26. The conviction held with gentleness prepares the responsible theologian of Lecture 34.

For the professor. This lecture asks for balance above all, so resist letting the class slide into either ditch, the contempt that despises the neighbour or the relativism that dissolves the Gospel. Keep both hands full at once: Christ the one Saviour, and the Spirit truly at work in the neighbour; proclamation, and dialogue. Make it intensely practical for life in Bengal, the Hindu and Muslim neighbours, the shared festivals and sorrows, the communal tensions, and form the students to be men of peace whose chief witness is love. End on the deep roots that make wide branches, so that they see that security in Christ is what makes true openness possible. Reading: Amaladoss on dialogue and pluralism, with *Nostra Aetate*. Reflection prompt: "A neighbour of another faith from whom I have learned something good, and how I would speak of Christ to him with both conviction and gentleness, is..."

LECTURE 34: What makes a theologian responsible?

The opening problem. The course is almost at its end, and the question now turns from the world to the student himself. He has learned the sources, the history, and the methods; he has faced the great questions of the age. But what kind of theologian will he be? And here a hard and old question rises, one that has troubled many a faithful thinker: is the responsible theologian the obedient one, who submits to the teaching of the Church, or the prophetic one, who dares to challenge and to question? Pose it as the students feel it, for they will feel it one day in their own ministry, when a teaching of the Church and their own honest thinking seem to pull apart, or when love for the poor seems to demand a word that authority is slow to speak. The temptation is to think one must choose, obedience or prophecy, the loyal servant or the bold critic. The teaching of this lecture, and of *Donum Veritatis*, is that this is a false choice. The responsible theologian is both faithful and honest, both obedient and prophetic, because true obedience is not servility and true prophecy is not rebellion, and the one who has learned to hold them together is the one this whole course has been forming.

The teaching content. The vocation, and the bond with the teaching office. Return to what the students learned in Lecture 14 about the bond between the theologian and the teaching office, and let *Donum Veritatis* deepen it. The theologian has a real and

honourable calling in the Church, to understand the faith more deeply and to express it for his own age; he serves the People of God, and he is bound, at once, to the Word of God, to the living Tradition, and to the legitimate teaching office, which is the servant and guardian of the Word. His freedom is real, but it is a freedom in the service of the truth and within the communion of the Church, and not the autonomy of a man who answers to no one. So the first mark of the responsible theologian is communion: he does not set himself up as a rival teaching authority, nor carry his every disagreement to the newspapers to pressure the Church, for that is not prophecy but faction.

Obedience that is not servility, and prophecy that is not rebellion. Now hold the tension open, as *Donum Veritatis* does in its treatment of the difficulties a theologian may face. The instruction recognises that a theologian may honestly find a difficulty with a teaching that is authoritative but not definitive, and it teaches him what to do: to study the matter deeply, to raise his questions through the proper channels and in a spirit of communion, with patience and with prayer, trusting that the patient and faithful work of theologians has often, in time, helped the whole Church to understand the faith more truly. This is obedience that is not servility, for it keeps the honest question alive and does not pretend to a false agreement; and it is the path the great theologians of Lecture 14 walked, Congar, de Lubac, and Schillebeeckx, who were silenced or investigated and who stayed, faithful, within the communion, some of them vindicated at last as the architects of a council. And what the students must see is that this very path is prophetic in the true sense. The prophet of Scripture spoke his hard word to the People of God from within the covenant, out of love for them, because he loved them too much to keep silent, and not from outside in contempt. The responsible theologian, who raises the hard question and stands with the poor and speaks the uncomfortable truth, while remaining in communion and under the Word, is the prophet on the wall of his own city, and not the deserter outside the gate.

Responsibility as accountability, and the gathering of the precepts. Bring the lecture, and the whole course, to its centre. To be responsible, in the sense of Lonergan that has ordered this unit, is to decide and to act and to answer for it, and the responsible theologian knows that he will give an account, to God above all, and also to the Church, to the truth, to the poor, and to the people he serves. His freedom and his accountability are not enemies but two sides of one trust, for he is, as Paul says, a steward of the mysteries of God, and of a steward it is asked only that he be found faithful (cf. 1 Corinthians 4:1 to 2). And here the four precepts of the whole course stand complete in one person. The responsible theologian is attentive, with the honesty of Unit III; intelligent, with the understanding of Unit IV; reasonable, with the judgement of Unit V; and responsible, with the decision and the accountability of this unit. To these the course has added what no precept can supply on its own and what Lecture 29 made plain: that he must be a person of prayer, of holiness, and of communion, for a theologian who is clever and faithless, learned and prayerless, has the tools of the trade and not its soul. The whole of it can be gathered in one old line of the prophet Micah, which the students might carry for life: to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God (Micah 6:8).

Illustration. The first image is the watchman on the wall. A city sets a watchman on its wall, and when he sees the enemy coming, or the first smoke of a fire, he cries out the warning

with all his strength, even though his cry wakes the sleepers and angers those who wished to rest. He is no traitor shouting from outside the gate; he is a loyal son of the city, set there to watch, who cries the warning precisely because he loves the city and would not see it burn. The prophet is such a watchman, and so is the responsible theologian: when he sees a danger to the faith or a wound in the People of God, he speaks the warning he is bound to speak, from within the city and out of love for it, and that speaking is not rebellion but the very duty of his post. The watchman who saw the fire and stayed silent, to keep the peace, would be the one who betrayed the city.

The second image is the steward who keeps the accounts and must answer for them. A master going on a long voyage entrusts his household and his goods to a steward, and gives him real freedom: the steward decides, manages, spends, and acts on his own judgement, day after day, trusted with much. But the steward knows that the master will return, and that he will give an account of his stewardship, and this knowledge does not cramp his freedom but ennobles it, for freedom and accountability are two sides of the one trust placed in him. The theologian is a steward of the mysteries of God, free to think, to question, to decide, and to act, and bound, all the while, to be found faithful when the account is asked. The servile man, who buries everything and risks nothing for fear of the reckoning, and the reckless man, who squanders the household as though no master would ever return, have both failed the one trust; the responsible steward is free and faithful at once.

References. The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Donum Veritatis: Instruction on the Ecclesial Vocation of the Theologian* (1990), sections 24 to 41, for the bond and the possible tension between the theologian and the teaching office, and for the right handling of difficulties in a spirit of communion. For the *sensus fidelium* and the grades of teaching, *Lumen Gentium* 12 and 25 (cross-reference Lecture 14). The watchman of Ezekiel 33, the steward of the mysteries of 1 Corinthians 4:1 to 2, and the call of Micah 6:8, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. The witness of Yves Congar, Henri de Lubac, and Edward Schillebeeckx, faithful within the communion (cross-reference Lecture 14).

Cross-references. This lecture completes the bond of the theologian and the teaching office begun in Lecture 14, and it gathers the four precepts that have ordered the whole course: attentive in Unit III, intelligent in Unit IV, reasonable in Unit V, and responsible in this unit. The prophecy from within reaches back to the marks and banks of Lecture 10 and to the hard cases of feminist theology in Lecture 28 and of Dalit and liberation theology in Lecture 26. The call to prayer and holiness comes from Lecture 29. The whole prepares the capstone of Lecture 35, where the student declares for himself what kind of theologian he will be.

For the professor. This is the climax of the teaching, the lecture in which the course turns its gaze on the student and asks who he will be, so give it weight and gravity. Refuse the false choice between obedience and prophecy, and show with living examples that the great faithful theologians were both, faithful within the communion and bold in their honest questioning, watchmen and not deserters. Stress that responsibility means accountability, and that the freedom of the theologian is the freedom of a steward who will give an account. End on Micah, slowly, for it gathers the whole course into one breath, and

let it lead straight into the Manifesto. Reading: *Donum Veritatis*, sections 24 to 41.

Reflection prompt: "A teaching or a situation where I can imagine feeling the pull between obedience and honest questioning, and how I would try to be faithful and honest at once, is..."

LECTURE 35: My Theology Manifesto

The opening problem. The road that began on the first day with the question, what is theology, has arrived at its destination, and the last question is the one toward which all the others have pointed: how do I become a responsible theologian today? This final session is not a lecture in the ordinary sense, and there is no examination to sit, for an examination would form the very thing this course has laboured against, the student who can repeat the answers and has decided nothing. Instead, each student is asked to take the whole course into his own hands and to write and to speak his own Theology Manifesto, a short and personal declaration, before God and before his brothers, of what theology is for him, why he does it, how he will do it, for whom, and in what spirit. This is the precept be responsible made flesh: not a thing learned, but a decision taken and spoken aloud and signed.

The teaching content. What the Manifesto is, and what it gathers. The Manifesto is the student answering, in his own voice, the six questions that have been the spine of the whole course. What is theology, for me? Why do I do it? How will I do it, with which sources and which methods? Who has authority over my thinking, and how will I stand within the communion of the Church? How does my work stand within the long history I have received? And, gathering all the rest, how do I become a responsible theologian today, here, in the real Bengal I will serve? In answering, the student draws together everything the course has given him: the four pillars on which he will stand, Scripture, Tradition, the experience of the faithful, and the cry of his people, from Lecture 23; the models he will reach for and the ones he must still learn, from Lecture 25; the threefold cord of dialogue with the cultures, the religions, and the poor, from Lecture 27; the questions of his own age, from Lectures 30 to 33; and, holding it all, the four precepts now complete in him, to be attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible, and the prayer without which, as Lecture 29 taught, the whole thing dies. The Manifesto is therefore not a new piece of content to be learned but the student gathering the whole course into a single, personal act of decision.

How to run it. Keep the form simple and serious. Ask each student to write a Manifesto of perhaps a page or two, in his own honest voice and not in borrowed phrases, and then to speak it aloud to the class, briefly, so that the decision is made before witnesses and not only on paper. The writing lets him think it through; the speaking makes it a commitment. The other students listen with respect, and the session becomes a kind of sending of the whole class. The Manifesto is the assessment of the course, in place of any examination, for it shows, better than any examination could, whether the student has not merely understood theology but has taken it up as his own responsibility. Tell the students that they will keep this Manifesto, and that they may read it again in five years, and in twenty, to

ask whether they have been faithful to the theologian they once stood up and declared they would become.

The spirit of it, and the close. Let the spirit of this last session be the spirit of the whole course gathered up: honest, joyful, prayerful, and sending. The student is not finishing a subject; he is beginning a lifelong calling, and he goes out from this room to a Bengal that needs him, to the poor, the Adivasi, the Dalit, the migrant, and the woman doubly burdened, to neighbours of many faiths, to a wounded earth, to a Church learning to listen, and to people who will meet the living God, or fail to, in part through the quality of his thinking and the depth of his prayer. He goes out, that is, as a responsible theologian, attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible, on his knees and on his feet. And so the course does not end with a full stop but with a sending and a blessing.

Illustration. The one image for this last session is the apprentice sent to his own bench. Through a long apprenticeship the young craftsman has watched the master, learned the tools, ruined some wood and saved some, and grown sure of his hands. And there comes a day when the master gathers the tools into the hands of the apprentice, no longer to practise on scraps but to make true things for real people, and says: the bench is yours now, and the work is yours, and the responsibility is yours; go and make well. This whole course has been such an apprenticeship, and the Manifesto is the day the tools are placed in the hands of the students and they are sent to their own benches, to do theology not as an exercise for a teacher but as a real work, on their own responsibility, for the real people of God. The master steps back; the craftsman steps forward; and the making, from this day, is his.

A blessing for the sending. Close the course, and these notes, with a blessing spoken over the students, that they may go out as responsible theologians of the living God. You may use words such as these, or your own:

May the God who is ever ancient and ever new, the Father who speaks his one Word in Jesus Christ and pours his Spirit upon the whole People of God, bless you who go out now to think and to pray and to serve. May you be attentive to his Word, his Tradition, his faithful people, and the cry of the poor of this land; intelligent to understand the faith you have received; reasonable to weigh and to choose with wisdom; and responsible to decide, to act, and to answer for your work before him. May you do your theology always upon your knees, rooted in Christ, faithful in his Church, and bold for the sake of his little ones. May you become, each one of you, a responsible theologian of this hour, and may the Lord, who began this good work in you, bring it to its completion. In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

References. The six questions that form the spine of the course, and the four precepts of Bernard Lonergan, be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible, from the architecture of the course and from Lecture 1. The four pillars from Lecture 23, the models from Lecture 25, the threefold cord from Lecture 27, the questions of the age from Lectures 30 to 33, and the marks of the responsible theologian from Lecture 34. Micah 6:8, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition, for the spirit of the whole.

Cross-references. This capstone gathers the entire course: the six goals and the opening question of Lecture 1; the four precepts that ordered Units III to VI; the four pillars of Lecture 23; the six models of Lecture 25; the streams of Lectures 26 to 29; the questions of the present age in Lectures 30 to 33; and the responsible theologian of Lecture 34. It is the destination toward which the sixth goal, how to become a responsible theologian today, has pointed from the first day.

For the professor. Guard this last session from becoming an anticlimax or a mere formality, for it is the point of everything that went before. Give the students time to write honestly, in their own voice, and require the speaking aloud, for the spoken word before witnesses is what turns understanding into commitment. Receive each Manifesto with respect, however simple, and resist correcting it into your own words, for it must be the student own decision and not yours. Let the session end in prayer, with the blessing, so that the men leave not as those who have passed a subject but as those who have been sent. Reading: their own Manifesto, written and then spoken. Reflection prompt, which is the Manifesto itself: "I will be this kind of theologian, doing theology in this way, for these people, in this spirit, because..."

CLOSING THE UNIT, AND THE CLOSE OF THE COURSE

With Unit VI the course reaches its destination. The students have faced the great questions of their own age, the machine that can arrange the words of theology without faith, the Church learning to walk together and to listen, the wounded earth whose cry is one with the cry of the poor, and the many faiths among whom they must speak of Christ with conviction and with gentleness; and they have learned what makes a theologian responsible, neither a servile man who risks nothing nor a rebel who breaks communion, but a faithful and honest steward of the mysteries of God, a watchman on the wall of the city he loves. Above all they have taken up the fourth and final precept of Lonergan, be responsible, and have found the other three completed in it, so that the responsible theologian stands before them, and within them, as one who is attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible, and who does all of it upon his knees.

And so the whole course is gathered into one. It began by asking what theology is, and it ends by asking each student to become a theologian. It moved from the nature of theology, through its sources and its history and its methods, to the doing of it today, and it has been ordered throughout by the six questions and the four precepts, grounded in the soil of India, in the poor and the Adivasi and the Dalit and the migrant and the woman, and held always under the Word of God and within the communion of the Church. The destination was never information but formation: not that the students should know about theology, but that each of them should become a responsible theologian of the living God, for the Church and the people of Bengal. That is the work the Manifesto declares and the blessing sends, and it is the work to which these notes, from the first lecture to the last, have been wholly directed.

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